The Epistemology of Coexistence

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The question: What is knowledge, who is the knower, and what is it that one can know? How are these concepts grounded in experience, and how does the Co-existentialism of Shri A. Nagraj compare with Advaita Vedanta, modern Western philosophy, and the natural sciences?

This study examines knowledge, the knower, and the knowable in **Madhyasth Darshan** (Co-existentialism), as presented by **Shri A. Nagraj**, and compares its answers with **Advaita Vedanta** and **modern science and philosophy**.

The Ontology of Coexistence supplies the ontological setting: Omnipresence, saturated units, the four orders, constitutional completeness, and the active structure of *jeevan*. The present study asks the specifically epistemological questions developed in *Manav Karm Darshan*: what knowledge is, what makes *jeevan* the knower, how coexistence becomes the known, and why understanding must become evident in action, relationship, evaluation, and humane tradition. Coexistence From First Principles is used as an interpretive audit of these connections, not as a primary source and not as a source of notation for this paper.

Standpoint and scope

These studies are written from the standpoint of a **scientist and technologist** — someone trained to graduate-level **physics and mathematics**, at home with contemporary cosmology, quantum theory, conservation laws, and the logic of formal models.

From that background, a familiar picture of nature is hard to avoid: **consciousness appears as something the brain does** — an epiphenomenon, functional outcome, or emergent property of particular configurations of very large numbers of physical particles. Modern physics and cognitive science are powerful on mechanism, prediction, and public evidence; yet the hard problem of consciousness, the status of the self, and the reality of value remain fiercely contested. The standpoint taken here does not treat those gaps as settled in favour of matter-only reductionism.

The work begins where that scientific picture leaves open questions — and asks whether Madhyasth Darshan offers a coherent alternative worth examining seriously. This paper reads the primary texts carefully, states what follows from the darshan itself, and compares it in parallel with what we know from **physics and the natural sciences**, **Advaita Vedanta**, and **modern Western philosophy** (especially epistemology and philosophy of mind). Physics and mathematics are **one leg** of that comparison, not the only one. The aim is rigorous comparative understanding — testing definitions, internal consistency, and fit with public knowledge — not persuasion or devotional endorsement.

These topical studies state the philosophy in clear, checkable prose first. A separate formal mathematical treatment may follow once the definitions and relations are stable across the studies; this paper does not assume or require that treatment.

1. The Madhyasth Darshan Answer

Madhyasth Darshan holds that knowledge is realised understanding of coexistence, *jeevan*, and humane conduct. The knower is the sentient *jeevan*, whose knowing becomes evident through the human joint form; the known is existence as coexistence, including the relationships and orderliness in which human beings participate. Knowledge is therefore neither accumulated information nor private certitude. It must guide deliberation before action, become evident in behaviour and work, and remain answerable to evaluation after the result appears.

This practical reach should be distinguished from the canonical content of complete knowledge. The four bodily *vishayas*, five sensory modalities, three *eshanas*, and *upakar* are not additional objects on the same doctrinal level as coexistence and *jeevan*. They identify the fields in which knowledge of humane conduct becomes operational. Within those fields, the human being must understand what activity is occurring, what criteria should govern the decision, what law protects and regulates the activity, what balance it must sustain, and how its result participates in overall orderliness.

1.1 Knowledge, knower, and known

Manav Karm Darshan gives the most direct account of the content of knowledge. Complete knowledge comprises the holistic view of existence as coexistence, knowledge of *jeevan*, and knowledge of humane conduct (KD §3.17, pp. 145–150; SB, p. 116). KD elsewhere counts knowledge of participation in overall orderliness as a fourth content (KD §3.5, p. 69). The difference is one of enumeration rather than a conflict between two doctrines. In the three-content formulation, participation is the completion and evidence of knowledge of humane conduct; in the four-content formulation, that participatory dimension is named separately. Neither account reduces knowledge to factual representation. What exists, who knows it, how the knower conducts human life, and how that conduct enters the larger order belong together.

The source texts also use *gyan* in a wider ontological register. Insentient and sentient nature saturated in Omnipresence is coexistence, while the omnipresent ground within coexistence is identified as Knowledge or Space; law, regulation, balance, justice, *dharma*, and ultimate truth are evident within coexistence (MVD, pp. 32–33). This language does not imply that every unit thinks or that Omnipresence is a universal mental subject. MVD describes Knowledge in this sense as actionless and non-transforming: it is neither an activity nor an agent performing activities, while serving as their ground and source of inspiration (MVD, p.

35). Units act; Omnipresence does not. The identification presents reality as orderly, intelligible, and available for realisation, not as a mind contemplating itself.

MVD argues for this pervasiveness from happiness as the *dharma* of the knowledge order: knowledge is its foundation, and what is absent cannot be attained, so knowledge must already be universally available (MVD, p. 115). The inference from an attainable goal to the prior presence of its ground is contestable, but it shows that pervasive *gyan* performs argumentative work in the darshan.

The activity of knowing belongs to *jeevan*. MVD distinguishes the universal presence of knowledge from its unfolding: knowledge is present throughout coexistence, while its unfolding occurs through awakened human beings and through the sentient aspect or thought (MVD, pp. 115–116, 289). Realisation in coexistence is complete knowledge; knowledge-unfolding is the awakened knower's expression of that realisation. *Jeevan* is the bearer of realisation, enlightenment, contemplation, deliberation, and selection. The human being is also called the knower because evidence requires the joint form of *jeevan* and body: a human being speaks, works, behaves, evaluates, teaches, and participates in orderliness. The two statements therefore concern different levels of one account. *Jeevan* bears knowing; the embodied human presents its evidence.

This relation becomes definite in MVD's account of how the omnipresent ground is available to an awakened human: as law in work, resolution in thought, bliss in realisation, and justice in behaviour (MVD, p. 33). The formula joins ontology to lived knowledge without treating its terms as synonyms; each names a distinct register in which understanding becomes evident. Realised knowledge ends contradiction in the knower as comprehensive resolution and becomes evident through lawful work, just behaviour, and non-contradictory participation.

The known is existence as coexistence. It includes Omnipresence and the four orders; units with form, properties, essential nature, and *dharma*; their relationships and participation; and development through awakening. Measuring external properties is one mode of knowing rather than its completion. KD distinguishes physical, intellectual, and coexistential knowledge, expressed through skill, proficiency, and scholarliness (KD, pp. 3–4). SB extends this scope into production and ecology: human freedom must protect and rightly use natural abundance rather than disrupt the complementarity of the other orders (SB, pp. 111, 121, 149). Particular material and ecological claims remain empirically testable.

KD says that the known becomes meaningful when awakening evidences human and *jeevan* aspiration through undivided society and universal orderliness. Coexistence is what is known; resolved, prosperous, fearless, and coexistential living shows that it has entered human meaning. The known is therefore neither an external object alone nor a desirable social result alone.

KD states the triad against idealist and god-centred systems that collapse knowledge, knower, and known into mystery, and against materialism's derivation of differences in consciousness from composition without, in KD's view, demonstrating the relation (KD §3.17, pp. 146–147). The common objection is that both obscure the human bearer of evidence. It does not resolve the strongest Advaita or physicalist arguments (§§2–4), but explains why Madhyasth Darshan requires knowledge to be borne and evidenced by the human joint form.

The same ontology treats *jeevan* as constitutionally complete and therefore persistent across bodily birth and death (JV, p. 20); the evidential standing of that proposition is examined in §7.4.

1.2 Why knowledge matters: awakening and the human goal

Knowledge matters because the knowledge order has happiness as its *dharma* yet possesses imagination and freedom of action without automatically possessing the understanding needed to direct them. Humans inherit a body continuous with orders whose composition, growth, and instinct exhibit definite patterns, but human conduct is not constitutionally fixed in the same way. People can accept incompatible beliefs, choose alternatives, organise production and institutions, and alter their environment. Knowledge is needed to bring that freedom into agreement with coexistence.

The immediate epistemic goal is freedom from delusion and comprehensive resolution. Delusion begins when the body is taken to be the self and sensory satisfaction is expected to fulfil *jeevan*. Resolution is not merely the cessation of anxious thought. MVD defines it as understanding the relevant realities together with adequate answers to why and how in activity (MVD, pp. 33, 311). Awakening is the condition in which reflection reaches understanding and understanding consistently governs projection into thought, choice, work, behaviour, and communication.

The four *jeevan* values name the inward harmonies of this condition: happiness between *mun* and *vritti*, peace between *vritti* and *chitta*, contentment between *chitta* and *buddhi*, and bliss between *buddhi* and *atma* (MVD, pp. 207–208; JV, p. 138). They are relations among activities of *jeevan*, not quantities on one scale. Material success cannot compensate for unresolved understanding, and private calm cannot substitute for unjust relationship. MVD calls their realisation mental well-being, while a further concurrence of *atma* with Omnipresence is described as ultimate bliss (MVD, pp. 208, 327).

These inward values become meaningful with the human goal of resolution in the individual, prosperity in the family, fearlessness in society, and coexistence in universal orderliness (KD §3.17, p. 150; JV, pp. 61, 165). Prosperity means the assured availability of physical means in excess of properly assessed need, not unlimited accumulation. Fearlessness depends on trust, justice, and freedom from exploitation rather than protection through domination. Coexistence at the social level means participation without contradiction in an undivided society and universal orderliness. The human goal therefore joins epistemic, material, relational, social, and coexistential fulfilment without allowing one to substitute for another.

KD says that resolution bears happiness, resolution with prosperity bears peace, the addition of fearlessness bears contentment, and participation in coexistence bears bliss (KD, p. 112). Its opening chapter similarly reinterprets the classical human ends through all-round resolution, realisation, and freedom from delusion (KD, pp. 3–4). These formulations are not one mechanical ladder. They share the requirement that inward understanding, bodily sufficiency, just relationship, social confidence, and universal participation be mutually consistent.

Madhyasth Darshan distinguishes three functions within this movement. Knowledge (*gyan*) establishes realised understanding of coexistence, *jeevan*, and humane conduct. Wisdom (*vivek*) recognises the human goal. Science (*vigyan*) supplies direction for accomplishing material prosperity together with the human and *jeevan* goals (MVD, p. 170). Science here is broader than modern natural science, although it remains answerable to physical evidence wherever it makes claims about production, health, ecology, or material process. Knowledge establishes what is real, wisdom identifies the human goal, and science determines how activity can move toward material sufficiency and those goals.

Constitutional completeness establishes *jeevan* as a sentient unit; activity and conduct completeness concern awakening. Activity completeness is the restfulness of internal effort when understanding is no longer divided by delusion, and conduct completeness is its stable expression in work, relationship, behaviour, and participation. Knowledge is sought neither for speculative possession nor private release alone, but for an evidence-bearing life in which inward resolution and outward participation agree.

1.3 *Jeevan*, body, and deliberation

The active knower is *jeevan*, a constitutionally complete sentient unit whose ten activities are distributed across *atma*, *buddhi*, *chitta*, *vritti*, and *mun*. JV names realisation and authenticity in *atma*; enlightenment and resolve in *buddhi*; contemplation and visualisation in *chitta*; deliberation and analysis in *vritti*; and taste and selection in *mun* (JV, pp. 72–73, 92–93). KD sometimes renders the receptive activity of *chitta* as direct recognition (*sakshatkar*). The common point is the recognition and formation of meaning rather than bodily sensation alone.

The activities have two coordinated directions. Reflection is the movement in which sensation, behaviour, thought, desire, and resolve are examined toward enlightenment and realisation. Projection is the movement in which realised understanding and resolve take form as visualisation, analysis, selection, bodily action, work, behaviour, and communication (KD §§3.12, 3.16–3.17). Knowing and acting are therefore recurrent phases of one active *jeevan*. Projection gives reflection material to evaluate; corrected reflection guides subsequent projection.

The body is necessary to this evidence but is not the knower. MVD describes the brain or *medhas* as processing signals associated with hopes, thoughts, desires, resolves, and authenticity, while waves from the cognitive organs participate in knowledge-unfolding (MVD, pp. 83–84, 200). KD claims that the body operates on the basis of *jeevan* and its understanding, not conversely (KD §3.16, pp. 141, 143). How this claimed direction of dependence interacts with neural activity remains open (§7.3).

The distinction between sensitivity and cognisance specifies the two sides of the joint form. Sensitivity (*sanvedansheelta*) is embodied responsiveness through sound, touch, sight, taste, and smell. Cognisance (*sangyansheelta*) is the knowing-and-accepting capacity through which *jeevan* understands relationship, value, purpose, and orderliness. Sensory contact is required for bodily interaction but does not by repetition yield the continuous satisfaction sought by *jeevan*. The awakened human regulates sensitivity through cognisance, while retaining both in balance. SB accordingly says that recognition and fulfilment of the insentient and sentient world occur through the balance of cognisance and sensitivity (SB, p. 64).

In delusion, four and a half of the ten activities are said to become effective: selection and taste, analysis, visualisation, and the part of deliberation governed by pleasure, health, and profit (JV, pp. 72–74; KD §3.17, p. 147). The remaining activities do not become evident because the body is taken as the self and reflection does not reach effective enlightenment and realisation. Projection consequently remains governed by sensory and material criteria. Awakening does not add another body or abolish sensory activity. Reflection reaches *buddhi* and *atma*, and realisation then informs visualisation, analysis, selection, and conduct through the full organisation of *jeevan*.

MVD calls inspiration reaching *mun* from *vritti*, *chitta*, *buddhi*, and *atma* higher-conformance aligned with justice, and pressure from vitality, senses, body, and established behaviour lower-conformance (MVD, p. 208). The latter is necessary to bodily maintenance; error arises when it defines *jeevan*'s final purpose. The question is which perspective governs bodily signals, material outcomes, and the selection that follows.

1.4 From sensory activity to universal orderliness

Knowledge of humane conduct becomes operational across bodily, sensory, social, and higher-human activity. These are connected fields rather than equivalent sets of drives. The four *vishayas* identify bodily propensities; the five sensory modalities identify the body's interfaces with its surroundings; and *samadhan* with the three *eshanas* identifies intellectual and social fulfilment. The primary texts distinguish temporary sensory satisfaction, longer-lasting intellectual satisfaction, and non-transforming satisfaction in realisation (MVD, pp. 64–65). *Upakar* belongs to a separate higher-human field of help and inspiration.

The four bodily *vishayas* are eating, sleeping, protection or defence, and mating (MVD, p. 58). They characterise animal living, and the human body retains rather than transcends its need for nourishment, rest, protection, and continuity. These propensities operate through the sensory fields of sound, touch, visible form, taste, and smell (MVD, p. 65). The two enumerations answer different questions. The four identify which bodily propensity is being served; the five identify the mode of bodily contact and information through which engagement occurs. They should therefore not be presented as nine independent activities.

MVD uses *samvedana* broadly for sensing, knowledge of the cognitive and work organs, or a tendency toward development (MVD, p. 313). "Five sensory modalities" is therefore more precise than "five *samvedanas*"; no stable five-member category parallels the four *vishayas*. Bodily propensities are not opposed to knowledge. Eating, for example, can be pleasant, health-supporting, and affordable while also being chosen with regard to justice, ecology, family need, and right use. The issue is governance, not suppression of bodily life.

The next field comprises resolution and the three *eshanas*. MVD groups satisfaction from *samadhan*, *vitteshana*, *putreshana*, and *lokeshana* as intellectual satisfaction, distinguishing it from temporary sensory satisfaction and non-transforming satisfaction in realisation (MVD, pp. 64–65). Read functionally, *samadhan* orients the social motives so that they become fields of understood responsibility rather than desires merely pursued.

The wealth motive, *vitteshana*, is not defined as accumulation. It is the wish for wealth acquired with the perspective of justice and directed toward right use. The progeny motive, *putreshana*, concerns human strength for family and social orderliness together with confidence in continuity. The public-recognition motive, *lokeshana*, is the wish for recognition in service of undivided society and universal orderliness under justice and *dharma* (MVD, p. 65). These definitions are normative: they name the humane form of each motive. Hoarding is not mature *vitteshana*, lineage domination is not mature *putreshana*, and fame-seeking is not mature *lokeshana*. Each becomes a field of responsibility when governed by resolution and humane perspective.

Upakar belongs to a higher-human level. MVD defines it as help and inspiration for prosperity and awakening (MVD, p. 73). It is neither a fourth *eshana* nor an ordinary bodily activity, but the use of resolved capacity to support another person's material sufficiency and understanding. This definition implies that help should increase capability and preserve mutuality; creating dependency or exploiting vulnerability would defeat its stated ends.

Before acting within these fields, *jeevan* deliberates through six perspectives. *Priya–apriya* evaluates what is pleasant or unpleasant in relation to sensory engagement. *Hita–ahita* evaluates nourishment, bodily health, and harm. *Labha–alabha* evaluates goods, services, exchange, and material gain or loss. *Nyaya–anyaya* evaluates behaviour in relationship. *Dharma–adharma* evaluates resolution and orderly participation. *Satya–asatya* evaluates whether understanding accords with realisation in existence (MVD, pp. 66–67). Thought is the definite analysis resulting from comparison across these perspectives (MVD, p. 71).

The first three perspectives are relative to changing conditions. What tastes pleasant may damage the body; what improves bodily comfort may depend on an unjust exchange; what appears profitable to one family may externalise harm to another or to the natural orders. Pleasantness, health, and material gain therefore provide relevant information without supplying a universal criterion. The latter three ask whether the decision fulfils relationship, sustains resolution and orderliness, and accords with coexistence. MVD accordingly classifies behaviour resting on *priya–hita–labha* as inhumane and behaviour resting on *nyaya–dharma–satya* as humane (MVD, p. 67). JV similarly calls for pleasure, health, and profit to be dissolved into or governed by justice, *dharma*, and truth (JV, pp. 93–98, 139).

This distinction does not require awakened humans to ignore pleasure, health, or economic result. The body still requires nourishment, protection, and useful means. Their subordinate status means that they cannot finally authorise an activity that violates justice, produces contradiction, or depends on a false conception of coexistence. Humane deliberation considers all six dimensions while giving governing authority to justice, *dharma*, and truth. MVD makes the contrast more strongly by calling deliberation through *nyaya–dharma–satya* balanced and deliberation through *priya–hita–labha* unbalanced (MVD, pp. 126–127). A source-faithful exposition can preserve that hierarchy while recognising that bodily and material information remains necessary to practical judgment.

Knowledge of activity also includes *niyam*, *niyantran*, and *santulan*. *Niyam* is law: MVD defines it as the way an activity is protected and disciplined (MVD, p. 70). *Niyantran* is regulation according to law, not arbitrary external control. *Santulan* is the balance sustained when activity remains appropriately regulated in mutuality. These terms concern the inherent and practical order of activity: what the relevant law is, how the activity stays within it, and what complementarity or balance results.

MVD gives a continuous sequence. Omnipresence is knowledge; realisation in knowledge is understanding; understanding is evidenced as knowledge, wisdom, and science; knowledge is law; law is regulation; regulation is balance; balanced human living is justice; just living in universal orderliness is *dharma* or resolution; and realisation in coexistence is *dharma* and truth (MVD, p. 174). The sequence connects two triads, but it does not establish three lexical equations in which *niyam* simply equals *nyaya*, *niyantran* equals *dharma*, and *santulan* equals *satya*. Elsewhere MVD says that human behaviour is regulated through justice, thought is disciplined through *dharma*, realisation occurs through truth, and regulation proceeds through law (MVD, p. 137). The source therefore supports a functional progression rather than a one-to-one mapping.

Law, regulation, and balance describe the order according to which activities occur and remain complementary. Justice, *dharma*, and truth describe the awakened human's understanding and fulfilment of that order in behaviour, thought, participation, and realisation. Law becomes humanly evident when activity protects rather than destroys the relationship on which it depends. Regulation becomes evident when choice remains aligned with the accepted purpose. Balance becomes evident when the result is mutually fulfilling rather than merely advantageous to one party. Justice, *dharma*, and truth are not labels attached after the event; they govern the deliberation through which the activity is selected.

This practical organisation gives humane conduct its definite content. KD describes humane conduct through value, character, and ethics. Value includes recognising relationship, fulfilling its values, evaluating the result, and attaining mutual satisfaction. Character includes fidelity and compassionate work and behaviour. Ethics includes the protection and right use of body, mind, and material wealth across personal, economic, and political participation (KD §3.4, p. 67). MVD describes humane behaviour through an essential nature of fortitude, courage, generosity, kindness, grace, and compassion; perspectives of justice, *dharma*, and truth; and behaviour bearing the three *eshanas* (MVD, p. 35). Humane conduct is thus neither a private disposition nor a list of prohibitions. It is the organisation of motive, deliberation, relationship, resources, and action under understood order.

The full movement begins from understood reality. *Jeevan* then deliberates through the applicable perspectives, decides what is to be done, recognises the relationship involved, and fulfils its value through embodied action. The result is evaluated for actual fulfilment and mutual satisfaction. Evaluation may confirm the original understanding, expose inadequate ability or resources, or reveal an error in conception, recognition, or choice. Corrected understanding then enters the next cycle. Knowledge is therefore active before, during, and after conduct: as understanding before decision, regulation during activity, and evaluation after result.

Across bodily propensities, sensory contact, the *eshanas*, relationship, production, and *upakar*, knowledge of the activity, its governing perspectives, relevant law and regulation, expected balance, and contribution to the human goal enables conscious participation in universal orderliness rather than the imposition of a human design upon nature.

1.5 Evidence, correction, and transmission

JV defines knowledge in the human process as knowing together with believing or accepting: "Knowing and believing constitute knowledge" (JV, p. 165). MVD expresses the same discipline as "Believe what is known; know what is believed" (MVD, p. 12). Acceptance here is not assent without inquiry. It is the establishment of understood meaning as a basis for one's own activity. Knowing without acceptance remains verbally available but practically ineffective; acceptance without knowing remains inherited belief and can sustain delusion.

Activity together with aspiration is karma, and every karma has a result. KD analyses intentional activity through doer, cause, objective, result, and effect, requiring desire, action, and consequence to be examined together rather than treating good intention as sufficient (KD Ch. 1). Bodily capacity, knowledge, skill, other persons, material means, and environmental conditions all mediate the result. An awakened decision does not guarantee control over every external event. It seeks non-contradiction between the accepted aim, the chosen means, the relationships involved, and the foreseeable result.

Result returns to the knower through evaluation. In relationship, recognition, fulfilment, evaluation, and mutual satisfaction together constitute justice (MVD, pp. 310–311; JV, p. 55). A person may know a stated value yet fail to recognise the present relationship, recognise it but lack the ability to fulfil it, act without adequate means, or claim fulfilment without examining the other person's experience. Evaluation is therefore not a final score added after conduct. It tests the entire movement from conception to consequence.

MVD identifies over-evaluation, under-evaluation, and mis-evaluation as characteristic failures. Over-evaluation attributes more value, capacity, or fulfilment than is present. Under-evaluation recognises less. Mis-evaluation applies the wrong value or criterion. Any of the three may distort the object, the accepted purpose, the relationship, one's own ability, the action, or the result. Repeated evaluation and action shape *sanskar*, which influences later projection without making human conduct mechanically fixed. The feedback movement is epistemic: consequence supplies material for corrected understanding.

MVD treats false learning as more than an isolated false proposition: it is failure to understand a thing's form, properties, essential nature, and *dharma* as they are, and is connected with doubt and distorted evaluation (MVD, pp. 184, 263–264). Information, argumentative skill, or institutional authority may therefore coexist with unresolved desire and unjust conduct. Awakening requires coherence across knowing, accepting, recognising, fulfilling, and evaluating.

MVD states its evidence chain as "Realisation – Behaviour – Experiment" (MVD, p. 12). The same passage says that realisation is ultimate evidence, evidence is understanding, understanding becomes manifest as resolution, work, and behaviour, and this manifestation sustains an awakened tradition. Realisation is the inward term; behaviour is its relational expression; experiment is the practical extension in which understanding encounters material and social result. Experiment includes productive and lived participation, not only controlled laboratory procedure.

This is a broader evidence regime than that of the natural sciences. Madhyasth Darshan requires first-person realisation, second-person conveyance, and publicly observable work, behaviour, and outcomes to cohere. It does not follow that admirable conduct proves every ontological assertion by scientific standards. A person may behave well while holding a mistaken cosmology, and a successful production method may not verify the proposed constitution of *jeevan*. Conduct-evidence is strongest for claims about resolution, relationship, and humane participation; claims about physical process, neural causation, or post-death continuity require domain-appropriate public tests (§§7.2–7.4).

Nagraj's founding questions ask whether evidence lies in the word or its bearer, in authoritative statement or its enunciator, and in scripture or its propounder (KD, *Alternative*, point 10). Madhyasth Darshan places the centre of gravity in the evidence-bearing human rather than the verbal formula alone. This use of *pramana* differs from classical accounts that primarily classify sources or instruments of valid cognition. Perception, inference, and testimony still participate in study, but none completes knowledge merely by producing a statement that is accepted as true.

KD describes direct perception as what can be brought into experiential proximity, inference as reaching beyond present proximity, and testimony-activity as addressing what lies beyond that inferential reach (KD, pp. 20–21). Sensory contact is not identical with *pratyaksha*, nor *pratyaksha* with realisation. The senses establish body–world contact; *chitta* recognises meaning, *buddhi* receives enlightenment and resolve, and *atma* realises and bears authenticity. Transmitted language can therefore occasion understanding without becoming knowledge merely by being heard.

Nagraj reports that *samadhi* quieted expectation, thought, and desire but did not by itself make the unknown known; he attributes the claimed direct seeing of coexistence to *samyama* and presents the resulting darshan for study and verification (KD, *Alternative*, points 1, 5, and 11). For subsequent learners, study includes language, definition, comparison, reflection, practice, work, and behaviour, and is oriented toward realisation in coexistence from the beginning (MVD, p. 35).

The primary texts do not prescribe a guaranteed ladder from information to realisation. Language and an evidence-bearing teacher make meaning available for examination; knowing and accepting establish it as a serious possibility; *chitta* recognises it, *buddhi* receives enlightenment and resolve, and *atma* realises. Projection returns understanding as explanation, conduct, work, and experiment; result and evaluation return to reflection. Information is necessary to transmission but is not already knowledge, and correct terminology establishes none of the later activities by itself.

Transmission remains essential because knowledge claims to be universally accessible rather than a private revelation that must remain ineffable. JV says that comprehension is tested by the capacity to convey it to others (JV, p. 26). Conveyance requires more than fluency. The learner must be able to explain, live, evaluate, and make the understanding available without contradiction. *Sanskar*, environment, study, endeavour, humaneness, and awakening support one another in this process (MVD, pp. 90, 290).

MVD recognises exploration and study through an awakened tradition as paths out of intellectual mystery, requiring delusion-less knowledge, just behaviour, resolved thought, and disciplined engagement with a realised teacher (MVD, pp. 273–285, 317). The resulting tradition joins guidance with the learner's examination of meaning, practice, consequence, and contradiction; the epistemic risks of dependence on teacher-evidence are examined in §7.5.

On this account, whatever is called knowledge must become intelligible in the knower, directive in action, examinable in consequence, communicable to another, and non-contradictory with the coexistence it claims to understand.

2. The Advaita Vedanta Answer

Advaita Vedanta gives two answers to the question of the knower, and comparison becomes distorted if they are collapsed. Within empirical life (*vyavahara*), an embodied person cognizes through perception, inference, testimony, and the other accepted means of knowledge. From the absolute standpoint (*paramartha*), the witnessing Self is not one individual knower among others: it is non-dual consciousness, identical with Brahman, in which the distinction between knower, known, and knowing does not finally apply. The world is consequently valid for empirical cognition while remaining *mithya*, dependent rather than independently absolute.

2.1 Empirical knower and witnessing consciousness

Classical Indian epistemology analyses a cognition through a subject or knower (*pramatr*), a means of knowledge (*pramana*), an object (*prameya*), and the resulting valid cognition (*prama*). Advaita accepts this structure at the empirical level. The embodied *jiva*, equipped with body, senses, and the internal organ (*antahkarana*), is the person who sees, infers, remembers, deliberates, and acts. *Ahamkara*, the appropriating "I"-notion, is one function in this empirical complex; it is not simply a synonym for the whole *jiva*.

Later Advaita manuals commonly describe cognition through a modification of the internal organ (*antahkarana-vritti*) that takes the form of an object and is illumined by consciousness reflected in the mind (*chidabhasa*). The actionless witness (*sakshin*) does not perform an epistemic operation alongside perception or inference. It is that by whose presence the changing cognitions of the empirical subject are manifest. The seer–seen discrimination makes this distinction vivid: whatever can itself be observed cannot be the final witness.

> **"The form1… is perceived and the eye… is its perceiver… It… is perceived and the mind… is its perceiver. The mind with… modifications is perceived and the Witness (the Self) is verily the perceiver… But… is not perceived…"**
> — *DDV, p. 15*

The physical body, senses, emotions, and thoughts are all available as objects of awareness; Advaita therefore denies that any one of them is the ultimate seer. Bhagavad Gita 13.1–3 distinguishes the body as "field" from its knower and then identifies the one knower in all fields. At the empirical level, however, different persons remain accountable agents and knowers. The text does not license replacing every ordinary act of knowing with an actionless transcendental observer.

The *Mandukya Upanishad* (MU, vv. 3–7) analyses waking, dream, and deep sleep before indicating *turiya*. Deep sleep is not simply a blank witnessed as another object: *prajna* is described as undifferentiated, a mass of consciousness and a causal condition in which distinct objects are not cognized, while ignorance remains. *Turiya* is neither an additional experiential state nor the deep-sleep condition; it is the non-dual Self that is not exhausted by any of the three.

The five-sheath analysis associated with the *Taittiriya Upanishad* (TU, 2.1–2.5), and developed explicitly as a method of discrimination in later works such as the *Vivekachudamani* (VC, vv. 154–212), similarly refuses to identify the Self with food-body, vitality, mind, intellect, or causal bliss. Madhyasth Darshan reuses some of the same *kosha* vocabulary but assigns it a different role: its layers are activities and powers of an enduring *jeevan* to be understood in awakened participation, not coverings whose discrimination culminates in the unreality of individual separateness (The Ontology of Coexistence §5.7.2).

2.2 Empirical knowledge and liberating knowledge

Advaita does not reduce every instance of knowledge to mystical realization. Perceptual and inferential cognitions can be valid within empirical life: a person may know a pot, a medical fact, or another person's testimony without thereby knowing Brahman. Liberating knowledge (*brahma-jnana*) is different in scope. It removes the basic superimposition by which the non-objectifiable Self is taken to be a limited body-mind and reveals the identity indicated by the Upanishadic great sayings.

> **"Brahman is truth, knowledge, infinite."**
> — *TU, 2.1.1*

The *Taittiriya* expression *satyam jnanam anantam brahma* describes Brahman as reality, consciousness or knowledge, and infinitude. It should not be presented as though the Upanishadic sentence were itself the later compact formula Sat-Chit-Ananda. Advaita receives that later formula as a convergent characterization: not three properties added to a substance, but indications of partless reality as existence, consciousness, and fullness. Consciousness is self-revealing (*svaprakasha*); it is not known by a second consciousness, which would generate an infinite regress.

> **"By that alone he comes to know his own Self as Existence-Knowledge-Bliss Absolute and becomes happy."**
> *— VC, v. 152*

Ordinary knowledge preserves the knower–means–known relation. Liberating knowledge removes the ignorance that made this relation appear finally independent. Brahman is consequently not a supreme object known by a surviving individual subject, nor an "absolute knower-known ground" in which both terms retain their ordinary meanings. At *paramartha*, the relational triad no longer applies.

2.3 Error, sublation, and levels of reality

Shankara opens the *Brahma Sutra Bhashya* by diagnosing mutual superimposition (*adhyasa*): the properties of body and mind are attributed to the Self, while consciousness and selfhood are attributed to the body-mind complex. Ordinary perceptual error, such as mistaking a rope for a snake, illustrates correction by sublation (*badha*): what appeared is cancelled by a cognition that discloses its substrate. Later Advaita develops this into the technical account of *mithya* as neither independently real nor sheer non-being.

The familiar three-level scheme is a useful later systematization rather than a single doctrine laid out as a table by Shankara. It distinguishes private or apparent error (*pratibhasika*), shared empirical order (*vyavaharika*), and the non-dual absolute (*paramarthika*).

Level	What is known?	Status of error
Apparent (*pratibhasika*)	Rope-snake, dream objects, private errors	Sublated by waking or correction
Empirical (*vyavahara*)	Bodies, minds, Ishvara, causes, duties, scriptures, science	Shared, law-governed; operationally valid; sublated only by *brahma-jnana*
Absolute (*paramartha*)	Brahman, not as an object opposed to a subject	Knower–known plurality is sublated

At *vyavahara*, the world is not unreal in the way a hallucination is. It is the common field in which evidence, error, causal order, duty, and instruction operate. Its dependence is disclosed only relative to Brahman. Madhyasth Darshan rejects this final sublation: error is removable misidentification within a fully real coexistence, not an epistemic condition whose removal cancels the ultimate independence of plurality (§1.5).

2.4 The nature of the knower

At *vyavahara*, the knower is the embodied *jiva*: the Self apparently delimited by body, senses, internal organ, ignorance, and agency. This empirical subject is neither identical with *ahamkara* alone nor dismissed as a hallucination. It is the bearer of responsibility, qualification, inquiry, and liberating instruction so long as ignorance persists. The witness is actionless, but the empirical knower performs cognition and action.

At *paramartha*, Brahman is one without a second (*ekamevaditiyam*, CU 6.2.1). Separate knowers cannot therefore be finally independent entities. The language of limiting adjuncts (*upadhi*), reflection, and superimposition explains how one consciousness appears as many knowers without undergoing real division. These explanatory models are pedagogically related but should not be treated as a single literal mechanism accepted identically by every Advaita author.

Ishvara is Brahman associated with Maya and functions within *vyavahara* as the omniscient source and governor of ordered name-form manifestation. Advaita commonly treats Ishvara as both material and efficient cause of the empirical universe, not merely an external operative cause and not a creator *ex nihilo*. The individual *jiva* is conditioned by individual ignorance; later pedagogical texts distinguish this from cosmic Maya, although terminology varies across authors. Both distinctions cease at *paramartha*:

> **“These two are the superimpositions of Ishwara and the Jiva respectively, and when these are perfectly eliminated, there is neither Ishwara nor Jiva.”**
> *— VC, v. 244*

The *Vivekachudamani* passage is useful evidence for a later pedagogical presentation, but its attribution to Shankara is disputed. The same caution applies to the *Drig-Drishya-Viveka*. They illuminate the received Advaita tradition without replacing the Upanishads, Bhagavad Gita, and Shankara’s securely attributed commentaries as primary anchors. Full causal and cosmological comparison appears in The Ontology of Coexistence §§2.4–2.5.

2.5 The nature of the known

Empirical objects, persons, space, time, and causal relations are knowable within the shared world. Their empirical validity is not denied whenever one sees or names them correctly. Advaita denies that their differentiated forms possess self-sufficient reality apart from Brahman. CU 6.1.4 presents the clay analogy: transformations are names grounded in speech, while clay is the material reality through which the transformations are understood.

> **"A firm conviction of the mind to the effect that Brahman is real and the universe unreal, is designated as discrimination (Viveka) between the Real and the unreal."**
> *— VC, v. 20*
>
> **"The individual soul is itself and directly the Supreme Brahman, and nothing else."**
> *— VC, v. 216*

The analogy does not make Brahman one more substance among substances. Nor does realization physically destroy the experienced world. It removes the claim that plurality exists independently and absolutely. The liberated person's continued experience belongs to *vyavahara*; the non-dual standpoint denies that this field establishes a second reality beside Brahman.

2.6 Means of knowledge and liberating instruction

Later systematic Advaita, represented by works such as Dharmaraja's *Vedanta Paribhasa*, normally accepts six means of valid cognition: perception (*pratyaksha*), inference (*anumana*), comparison (*upamana*), postulation (*arthapatti*), non-apprehension (*anupalabdhi*), and verbal testimony (*shabda*). Earlier Advaita presentations do not always enumerate or analyse them in exactly the same way. This historical qualification matters because the six-fold list is a mature scholastic account, not a verbatim scheme in every foundational text.

The word *pramana* is also a false friend in this comparison. In Advaita and other classical Indian epistemologies it means an instrument or source that generates valid cognition. In Madhyasth Darshan's English translations, "evidence" or *pramana* often names the lived confirmation of realization in conduct, work, participation, and conveyance. The two uses overlap around warrant but are not equivalent.

Means of cognition	Empirical competence	Limit in Advaita
Perception and inference	Objects, relations, causal and practical judgments	Operate through subject–object distinction
Comparison, postulation, non-apprehension	Linguistic learning, explanatory entailment, warranted absence	Establish empirical cognitions, not non-duality independently
Ordinary testimony	Knowledge received from competent speakers	Remains corrigible within shared life
Upanishadic *shabda*	Reveals the otherwise unavailable identity of Self and Brahman	Does not turn Brahman into a perceptible object

All means of knowledge function for a student within *vyavahara*. Upanishadic testimony is unique not because it operates as a *paramarthika* transaction outside duality, but because it removes ignorance about an identity unavailable to perception and inference. Shankara allows that a qualified student may understand the sentence at first hearing. Reflection (*manana*) removes intellectual doubt, and sustained contemplation (*nididhyasana*) addresses contrary dispositions or obstacles; they do not manufacture the validity of scripture after it was previously invalid.

The pedagogical discipline is conventionally expressed as hearing, reflection, and contemplation under a qualified teacher:

1. ***Shravana*** — hearing and understanding the Upanishadic teaching.
2. ***Manana*** — reasoning that resolves doubts about the teaching.
3. ***Nididhyasana*** — sustained assimilation where habitual contrary identification remains.

> **"The Self, my dear Maitreyi, should be realised—should be heard of, reflected on and meditated upon."**
> *— BU, 2.4.5*

First-person discrimination and *neti neti* (BU, 2.3.6) work within this teaching by withdrawing mistaken identifications. The comparison with Madhyasth Darshan's awakened tradition is therefore structural but limited. Both value an accomplished teacher and assimilated understanding; Advaita treats Upanishadic testimony as the decisive means for non-dual Self-knowledge, whereas Madhyasth Darshan asks realization to become publicly legible in humane conduct and successful conveyance (§1.5).

2.7 Liberation and complete knowledge

Liberating knowledge is not acquisition of a new property or merger of a formerly separate substance into Brahman. It is recognition of the identity taught by *tat tvam asi*, "That thou art" (CU, 6.8.7), through which ignorance of the ever-free Self is removed. BSB 1.1.2 should not be cited as the locus of this identity: it defines Brahman through the origin, continuance, and dissolution of the universe. Shankara's treatment of Upanishadic identity statements occurs across his commentaries and in the later sections of the *Brahma Sutra Bhashya*.

> **“There is neither death nor birth, neither a bound nor a struggling soul, neither a seeker after Liberation nor a liberated one – this is the ultimate truth.”**
> *— VC, v. 574*
>
> **“The Supreme Brahman is, like the sky, pure, absolute, infinite, motionless and changeless, devoid of interior or exterior, the One Existence, without a second, and is one’s own Self.”**
> *— VC, v. 393*

Advaita commonly distinguishes liberation while living (*jivanmukti*) from the final cessation of embodied appearance (*videhamukti*). Knowledge removes ignorance; the body-mind may continue through already-fructifying karma (*prarabdha*) without restoring the knower’s former identification. Accounts differ on the exact explanatory status of *prarabdha*, but the important comparative point is stable: no eternally separate *jiva* persists as an independent knower after liberation. Madhyasth Darshan instead holds that each *jeevan* remains numerically distinct and active in coexistence even when awakened (§1.1).

2.8 Ethics, *loka-sangraha*, and what realization evidences

Advaita does not treat ethical indifference as evidence of realization. The fourfold qualification (*sadhana-catushtaya*) requires discrimination, dispassion, disciplined virtues, and desire for liberation; the Bhagavad Gita’s disciplines of action and devotion purify the mind for knowledge. In Shankara’s account, action does not directly produce liberation, because an action cannot create the already existent Self. Ethical and contemplative disciplines prepare the knower, while knowledge removes ignorance.

The Bhagavad Gita’s explicit discussion of *loka-sangraha*, sustaining or protecting the world’s order, occurs at 3.20 and 3.25–26. Shankara allows that one who has no personal end left to gain may nevertheless act for the welfare and guidance of others. BG 3.8 establishes the necessity of prescribed action for the unliberated agent, but it should not carry the whole claim about enlightened social responsibility.

Domain	Valid at *vyavahara*	Status at *paramartha*
Ethics and duty	Required for qualification and social order (BG 3.8, 3.20, 3.25–26)	No separate agent remains with a personal end to achieve
World and nature	Law-governed, shared, beginningless cosmology	*Mithya* — dependent appearance
Individual self	Real as embodied *jiva* under *upadhi*	Identical with Brahman; separateness dispelled

Domain	Valid at *vyavahara*	Status at *paramartha*
Relationships and society	*Loka-sangraha*, ordained action for world-welfare	Not ultimately separate from Brahman
Time and change	Past, present, future, birth and death operationally valid	Sublated when timeless Self is known

Madhyasth Darshan's objection is therefore not that Advaita lacks ethical discipline or compassionate exemplars. It is that ethical action has a different epistemic and ontological place. In Madhyasth Darshan, mutually fulfilling conduct is constitutive public evidence of understanding in a perpetually real coexistence. In Advaita, ethical fitness prepares the mind and compassionate action may express freedom, but neither produces Self-knowledge nor makes relationships ultimately independent realities. The dispute concerns what conduct proves and what final weight the world retains.

2.9 Scope within Indian epistemology

Advaita is one major Indian answer, not a proxy for Indian epistemology as a whole. Nyaya defends enduring individual selves, a realist world, and a highly articulated theory of inference and testimony. Mimamsa develops distinctive accounts of linguistic authority and the intrinsic or extrinsic validity of cognition. Buddhist epistemologists analyse perception, inference, momentariness, and no-self without accepting Advaita's Brahman. A comprehensive cross-Indian comparison would therefore require a separate study. Advaita is retained here because its witness analysis, non-dual absolute, and theory of liberating knowledge create the sharpest contrast with Madhyasth Darshan's enduring plural knowers in coexistence.

3. Modern Western Epistemology and Philosophy of Mind

Modern Western philosophy offers no single answer to knowledge, knower, and known. Analytic epistemology asks what turns true belief into knowledge; philosophy of mind disputes whether the knower is wholly physical, emergent, embodied, socially constituted, or grounded in consciousness; phenomenological and perspectival approaches begin from lived experience rather than treating it as an afterthought. Physicalism is influential, but it is a contested philosophical position rather than the unanimous conclusion of analytic philosophy.

3.1 What is knowledge?

Analytic epistemology usually distinguishes **propositional knowledge**—knowing that something is the case—from knowledge-how, acquaintance, and understanding. The traditional justified-true-belief framework concerns propositional knowledge. Gettier (1963) showed that a belief may be justified and true through epistemic luck without amounting to knowledge, so contemporary accounts add or replace conditions involving reliability, safety, proper function, evidence, or intellectual competence.

Reliabilism locates warrant partly in dependable belief-forming processes rather than only in reasons accessible to reflection (Goldman 1979). Virtue epistemology treats knowledge as a success attributable to the knower's intellectual competence (Sosa 2007). Social epistemology examines testimony, trust, disagreement, institutions, and epistemic injustice, showing why an isolated individual is not the sole unit of assessment (Fricker 2007; Jarczewski and Riggs 2025). These theories compete; "modern Western epistemology" has no single accepted criterion.

Madhyasth Darshan's *gyan* does not map neatly onto any one of these categories. It includes understanding of coexistence and the human being, realization by the knower, and confirmation in conduct (§§1.1–1.5). Analytic epistemology can ask whether its claims are true, warranted, reliably formed, communicable, and socially responsible, but it will not ordinarily define humane conduct as part of what makes a proposition known. Scientific method, meanwhile, is an institutional way of producing and correcting empirical knowledge; it belongs to §4 rather than serving as the definition of knowledge in analytic epistemology.

3.2 Naturalistic accounts of the knower

Physicalist and naturalistic accounts identify knowing with capacities of embodied organisms or with cognitive processes realized by them (Churchland 1986; Dennett 1991). Some theories reduce mental states to physical or functional states; others treat consciousness and selfhood as emergent, embodied, enacted, or distributed across organism and environment. They agree less about consciousness than the label "naturalism" can suggest.

Many physicalists reject a Cartesian inner observer. On representational accounts, the self is a dynamically maintained self-model integrating perception, memory, bodily regulation, action, and social recognition. Enactive and embodied accounts resist the picture of a brain constructing an inner replica for a detached spectator; they locate cognition in skilled organism–environment engagement. Both differ from an indivisible *jeevan*, though for different reasons.

The causal closure of the physical is a philosophical thesis used in arguments for physicalism (Kim 2005), not a separately measured law stating that every event already has a sufficient physical cause. Conservation laws constrain physical quantities, but by themselves do not settle the metaphysics of mind or show that intention would have to "inject energy." The sharper challenge to Madhyasth Darshan is explanatory: if *jeevan* is distinct from the body yet affects neural action, the account needs a publicly assessable relation between its activities and measured brain processes. Without such criteria, physicalism remains contestable while *jeevan* remains empirically underdetermined.

3.3 Scientific realism and the scope of the known

Scientific realism is a philosophical interpretation of successful science: well-confirmed theories aim to describe a mind-independent world, including unobservable entities supported by explanatory and predictive success. Instrumentalists and constructive empiricists grant the practical and empirical success of theories without making the same commitment to their unobservable ontology. Science itself does not decide this dispute by methodological fiat.

The scientifically investigated world includes physical, biological, psychological, and social phenomena insofar as claims about them can be made publicly answerable to evidence. Public does not mean directly visible or purely quantitative: scientists infer unobservables, use models and instruments, and can treat disciplined first-person reports as data when collection and interpretation are calibrated. Spacetime in physics remains a mathematically articulated dynamical structure, not omnipresent knowledge-energy (The Ontology of Coexistence §4.5; *Nature of Time*).

Madhyasth Darshan expands the known to include relationship, value, *dharma*, and humane order as objective dimensions of coexistence (§1.1). Western philosophy contains realist and anti-realist accounts of value, while psychology and social science investigate moral cognition and institutions. Descriptive findings alone do not entail prescriptive conclusions without normative premises. The comparison should therefore oppose neither "physical facts" to "values" nor science to all normativity; it should ask what kind of evidence supports claims that values are features of reality rather than human responses, practices, or constructions.

3.4 The hard problem, mystery, and first-person evidence

Philosophy of mind distinguishes explanatory questions from the analysis of knowledge. Third-person accounts are powerful on mechanism and prediction, yet Chalmers's **hard problem** asks why and how physical processing is accompanied by subjective experience (Chalmers 1995; Nagel 1974):

> **"The really hard problem of consciousness is the problem of experience."**
> *— Chalmers 1995, p. 3*
>
> **"the fact that an organism has conscious experience at all means, basically, that there is something it is like to be that organism."**
> *— Nagel 1974, p. 1*

The argument begins from the reality of experience, but its conclusion is disputed. Reductive physicalists expect a functional or neuroscientific explanation; illusionists argue that the apparently ineffable properties attributed to consciousness are products of introspective representation (Frankish 2016); non-reductive physicalists treat experience as irreducible without making it a separate substance; panpsychists or Russellian monists assign experience or proto-experiential character a fundamental role (Strawson 2006; Goff 2019; Hashemi 2025).

These are philosophical positions constrained by science, not established findings of consciousness science.

The hard problem does not prove an extra-physical *jeevan*, and neural correlation does not by itself solve the hard problem. Madhyasth Darshan makes a stronger proposal: mystery (*rahasyata*) is a removable deficit in the knower's reflection, and disciplined realization can disclose the constitution and activity of the knower (§1.5). Comparative evaluation must therefore ask what such realization predicts, how it is distinguished from introspective error, and how first-person discrimination is coordinated with public evidence.

3.5 Error, bias, and epistemic correction

Western epistemology distinguishes several failures that should not be merged. A belief may be false, accidentally true, irresponsibly held, produced by an unreliable process, distorted by bias, or defeated by evidence the believer ignores. Testimonial injustice and institutional exclusion add social failures that cannot be located only inside an individual's reasoning. Gettier cases concern epistemic luck even when belief is justified and true; they are not examples of experimental non-replication.

Scientific practices address a subset of these failures through calibration, controls, statistical criticism, replication, adversarial testing, and revision. Phenomenology addresses another subset by examining how objects and selfhood are given in experience; psychotherapy, contemplative disciplines, and moral education address still others. None supplies an infallible correction regime.

Madhyasth Darshan foregrounds false learning, delusion, and contradiction between claimed understanding and conduct (§1.5). Advaita foregrounds superimposition and ignorance of Self (§2.3). Analytic epistemology asks whether belief is warranted and non-accidental, while science asks whether empirical claims survive public tests. The live comparison is not first-person against third-person correction, but how different kinds of error are diagnosed and how their proposed corrections become independently assessable.

3.6 Personal identity and brain death

Physicalism's answer to post-mortem persistence is typically negative: if personal capacities are realized by a living brain and organism, their irreversible destruction ends the person. Clinical criteria of death serve medical and legal decisions; they are not themselves a complete philosophical theory of personal identity. No reproducible public evidence has established the continued agency of an individual knower after bodily death.

Personal identity theory asks what, if anything, makes a person the same individual over time. Locke tied identity to **psychological continuity** — memory and connectedness of consciousness — rather than sameness of material particles. Parfit (1984) argued that what matters in survival is psychological connectedness, not a further fact of deep identity beyond the stream of mental states. On reductionist readings, the question "is this the same knower after death?” has no fact of the matter beyond causal and psychological links — which bodily death breaks (SEP Personal Identity).

Madhyasth Darshan’s *jeevan* (§1.1) and Advaita’s eternal *Atman* (§§2.4 and 2.7) both reject this outcome on different grounds. Physicalism sets a high evidential bar: without operational criteria for a non-neural knower or independent post-death evidence, immortal *jeevan* remains a metaphysical posit, while the hard problem (§3.4) exposes the incompleteness of current physical explanation without proving either rival view.

3.7 Social, embodied, and perspectival knowing

Phenomenology begins from intentionality: consciousness is consciousness *of* something, and objects are disclosed through embodied, temporal, and perspectival experience. Husserl’s suspension of the natural attitude is a methodological refusal to settle metaphysics before describing experience, not the Advaita conclusion that the experienced world is *mithya*. Merleau-Ponty’s embodied subject is not a detached witness behind the body; bodily orientation is constitutive of perceptual access to a shared world (SEP Phenomenology).

Embodied and enactive approaches carry part of this insight into cognitive science by treating cognition as skilled activity of organism and environment rather than passive construction of an inner picture. Perspectival realism holds that scientific knowledge is historically, instrumentally, and conceptually situated while remaining capable of truth about a mind-independent world (Massimi 2022). These positions give the knower’s standpoint a constructive role without making truth merely private.

Social epistemology adds that testimony, trust, expertise, institutions, and relations of power affect what people can responsibly know. It comes closer to Madhyasth Darshan’s emphasis on tradition and conveyance, but it evaluates testimonial competence and social conditions rather than presupposing an awakened lineage. The comparison is therefore not exhausted by “matter versus soul.” It also concerns whether knowledge is belief, reliable competence, lived disclosure, social achievement, understanding, or conduct-evidenced realization—and how first-person and public evidence constrain one another.

4. Modern Scientific Approaches

The natural sciences operationalise knowledge through observation, measurement, modelling, prediction, experiment, and replication. They do not ordinarily define a metaphysical knower. They investigate organisms, brains, behaviour, reports, and environments, while adopting methodological naturalism: explanations are sought in publicly testable processes rather than in unmeasured sentient units.

4.1 Method and means of knowing

Natural science adopts methodological naturalism: it seeks explanations through publicly testable processes without requiring a prior proof that only natural entities exist.

Measurement, formal models, experiment, and institutional criticism extend ordinary perception and inference (Popper 1959). Science can constrain philosophical accounts of mind, but an experimental result does not by itself select a complete metaphysics. SB likewise records that humans seek to live with evidence through experimentation, behaviour, and experience (SB, p. 44); Madhyasth Darshan extends that demand into realization and conduct (The Ontology of Coexistence §4).

The principal scientific practices do not map one-to-one onto Indian *pramana* lists, although some functions are comparable:

Modern source	Primary role	Limits for mind/self claims
Perception (incl. instruments)	Data acquisition from world and body	Theory-laden; does not directly observe non-physical *jeevan*
Inference and modelling	Hypothesis, prediction, mathematical structure	Multiple models may fit the same data; ontology requires further argument
Measurement and experiment	Controlled test of predictions	**Experiment** here means hypothesis-testing and replication — not Madhyasth Darshan's wider verification in production and lived orderliness (§1.5)
Testimony and trust	Collective knowledge via experts, records, education	Depends on epistemic communities; social virtue epistemology develops this (§3.7)
Replication and review	Error control across communities	Reliability varies by design, incentives, and access to evidence

Public accountability, rather than a ban on first-person evidence, is the governing standard. Pain ratings, perceptual reports, introspective confidence, and phenomenological interviews can enter research as data, but their elicitation and interpretation must be open to calibration and criticism. First-person experience is indispensable to consciousness research; it is not by itself evidence for immortal units or sufficient warrant for a metaphysical theory.

4.2 Brain, organism, and conscious report

Neuroscience establishes systematic dependence between brain activity and perception, memory, language, decision, and conscious report (Kandel et al. 2021). Injury, stimulation, anaesthesia, development, and degeneration alter the capacities attributed to a knower. These findings support brain-based accounts, but dependence does not by itself settle whether consciousness is identical with neural activity, emerges from it, or accompanies it under a deeper ontology.

Madhyasth Darshan accepts the brain as the body's enriched signal-processing organ while assigning understanding and evaluation to *jeevan* (§1.3). The scientific question is whether that distinction predicts anything beyond brain–behaviour models. A viable empirical programme would need operational markers of *jeevan*, not only philosophical dissatisfaction with physicalism.

4.3 Consciousness science and unresolved theory

Consciousness science contains competing research programmes, including global neuronal workspace, integrated information, higher-order, recurrent-processing, and predictive-processing accounts. Illusionism and panpsychism are broader philosophical interpretations, not programmes of the same experimental kind. Adversarial testing of IIT and GNWT has challenged distinctive predictions of both rather than selecting an uncontested winner (Melloni et al. 2025). This pluralism shows an unfinished explanatory field, not positive evidence for Madhyasth Darshan.

The hard problem remains the philosophical question of why physical processing should have a first-person aspect at all (§3.4). Experimental science can map neural correlates, behavioural capacities, and report conditions without resolving that metaphysical question. Madhyasth Darshan offers *jeevan* as its answer, but the existence and interaction of such a unit remain to be independently established.

4.4 Error control and public evidence

Scientific error correction depends on calibrated instruments, statistical discipline, replication, peer review, and adversarial testing. Its strength is that results need not depend on the moral or contemplative attainment of a particular observer. Its limits are equally clear: institutional procedures can reproduce shared assumptions, and third-person measures do not exhaust the first-person character of experience or the normative question of how knowledge should guide conduct.

Madhyasth Darshan's evidence chain and scientific replication therefore overlap only partly. Both require claims to face consequence and correction. Science privileges methodologically reproducible observations; Madhyasth Darshan additionally requires coherence among realisation, behaviour, work, relationship, and transmission (§1.5). The latter is broader, but breadth does not automatically supply the controls against suggestion, authority, and confirmation bias that science has developed.

4.5 Ethics, value, and life's purpose

Evolutionary biology can explain how cooperation, kin concern, punishment, and norm sensitivity developed; psychology and social science investigate empathy, reasoning, institutions, and cultural variation. These are explanations of capacities and practices, not by themselves proofs that a moral norm is true. Philosophical naturalists consequently divide among moral realism, constructivism, contractualism, expressivism, and error theory.

Survival and reproduction describe central consequences of natural selection, not a scientifically prescribed purpose for a human life. Purposes involving relationship, vocation, inquiry, justice, or flourishing require practical and ethical judgment. Science can illuminate their conditions and consequences but does not establish a single cosmic telos of awakening, liberation, or realization in coexistence.

Madhyasth Darshan makes a stronger unity claim: value, humane purpose, knowledge, and conduct belong to the objective order of coexistence and confirm one another (§§1.2 and 1.5). The scientific and philosophical challenge is to show how this normative order is known, how disagreement is corrected, and why successful conduct supports its ontology rather than only its practical usefulness.

4.6 Beyond simple brain reduction

Cognitive science is not restricted to a passive input–computation–output picture. Predictive-processing and active-inference approaches model an organism as anticipating sensory causes and acting to maintain viable states (Limanowski and Blankenburg 2013; Wiese 2024; Tufft et al. 2024). Embodied and enactive research instead emphasizes sensorimotor skill, bodily regulation, and environmental coupling (IEP Enactivism; Piredda 2024). Both make agency more distributed than a brain-only slogan suggests, while remaining compatible with naturalistic investigation.

Research that coordinates careful experiential reports with neural and behavioural measures offers a possible bridge between first-person and public evidence. Such work does not treat introspection as infallible: reports are trained, sampled, compared, and related to independently measured processes. This is methodologically closer to Madhyasth Darshan's demand that inner realization meet observable consequences, although it does not presuppose *jeevan* or humane conduct as the ontology and criterion of consciousness.

These developments leave open whether cognition is best described as representational or enactive, brain-bound or organism–environmental, and reducible or irreducible. They do not remove the principal scientific objection to Madhyasth Darshan: a distinct *jeevan* has no agreed operational marker that discriminates its contribution from brain–body dynamics.

Public science has established precise mechanism, prediction, and correction across many domains. It has not established immortal *jeevan* or post-death continuity of a sentient unit (§§1.1 and 7.4). An explanatory gap in consciousness is not an existence proof for *jeevan*; predictive accuracy alone does not settle whether the regulator is only neural or a distinct unit working through the brain (§7.3).

5. Comparison

Question	Madhyasth Darshan	Advaita Vedanta	Modern Western philosophy	Natural sciences
Knowledge	Realised understanding of coexistence, *jeevan*, and humane conduct, internally established as resolution and expressed through wisdom, science, and living	Valid empirical cognition at *vyavahara*; liberating knowledge of Self–Brahman identity	Propositional warrant, reliable competence, understanding, lived disclosure, or social achievement	Models and explanations supported by observation, prediction, experiment, and replication
Knower	*Jeevan* as active sentient bearer; human joint form as embodied evidence	Embodied *jiva* is empirical knower; *sakshin* illumines cognition; separate knower is sublated at *paramartha*	Organism, embodied subject, socially constituted person, or consciousness, depending on theory	Operationally, the organism and its measurable brain, behaviour, reports, and environment
Known	Coexistence as object; made meaningful through awakened human and *jeevan* aspirations	Empirical plurality at *vyavahara*; Brahman alone at *paramartha*	Mind-independent reality, experience, concepts, or socially mediated objects, depending on theory	Publicly investigable physical, biological, and behavioural processes
Method	Study, reflection, practice, behaviour, experiment, evaluation, and transmission	*Shravana*, *manana*, *nididhyasana*, and contemplative discrimination	Argument, phenomenological description, conceptual analysis, testimony, and epistemic practice	Measurement, modelling, controlled experiment, prediction, replication, and review

Question	Madhyasth Darshan	Advaita Vedanta	Modern Western philosophy	Natural sciences
Practical regulation	Cognisance regulates sensitivity, the four bodily propensities, and the three *eshanas* through justice, *dharma*, truth, and right use	Sense-restraint, ethical qualification, duty, and renunciation prepare and express liberating inquiry	Accounts range from self-regulation and virtue to embodied, social, and political practice	Homeostasis, behavioural control, health, and environmental sustainability are investigated descriptively and interventionally
Validation	Realisation and authenticity made evident in behaviour, work, relationship, mutual satisfaction, *upakar*, and teachable tradition	Empirical *pramanas* in their domains; Upanishadic *shabda* removes ignorance of identity	Justification, reliability, virtue, coherence, safety, or perspectival adequacy	Reproducible evidence and successful prediction under public methods
Error	Body–*jeevan* identification, incomplete faculty activity, false learning, and mis-evaluation	Superimposition and *anirvacaniya* error, sublated by knowledge	False belief, unreliable process, conceptual confusion, or situated distortion	Measurement error, bias, failed prediction, confounding, and non-replication
World status	Real and perpetual	Empirically valid but ultimately *mithya*	Realist, idealist, pragmatist, and anti-realist positions compete	Investigated as a stable public order; final metaphysics is not fixed by method alone

Question	Madhyasth Darshan	Advaita Vedanta	Modern Western philosophy	Natural sciences
Conduct	Humane conduct is content and evidence of knowledge; wisdom identifies goals and science determines practicable direction	Ethical discipline prepares and expresses realisation at *vyavahara*	Ethics and epistemic virtue are related but normally distinct from possessing knowledge	Ethical purpose is not derivable from descriptive results alone
Persistence	*Jeevan* persists across bodily death; asserted and inferred, not scientifically measured	Self is eternal Brahman; separate *jiva* is ultimately unreal	Substance, bodily, psychological, narrative, and reductionist accounts compete	Personal continuity is ordinarily tied to continuing brain and organism function
Goal	Happiness, peace, contentment, and bliss; resolution, prosperity, fearlessness, and coexistence	*Moksha* through knowledge of non-duality	Truth, rational agency, understanding, flourishing, or intellectual virtue	Explanation, prediction, intervention, and corrigible public knowledge

5.1 Key contrasts

The deepest ontological contrast is between perpetual plurality and non-dual dependence. Madhyasth Darshan holds Space and every material and sentient unit to be real in coexistence: *Brahma satya hai, jagat satat hai*. Advaita grants the world empirical validity but denies it independent absolute reality. Science investigates a stable public order without, by method alone, deciding between every realist and anti-realist interpretation; it offers no evidence that physical spacetime is omnipresent knowledge.

The accounts of the knower must be compared at matching levels. Advaita's empirical *jiva* perceives, reasons, acts, and bears responsibility; the witness is actionless and illumines these activities; at *paramartha*, no separate knower remains. Madhyasth Darshan's *jeevan* remains a distinct active sentient unit in both ignorance and awakening. Naturalistic approaches locate activity in brain, body, environment, and social practice. The contrast is therefore not simply an active knower against a passive one, but enduring plural agency against empirically operative agency whose separateness is finally sublated.

Knowledge and conduct also occupy different logical roles. Madhyasth Darshan places humane conduct within complete knowledge and treats its expression in behaviour, work, relationship, and conveyance as evidence (§§1.1 and 1.5). Advaita requires ethical qualification and permits liberated action for *loka-sangraha*, but conduct neither produces nor constitutes *brahma-jnana*. Western virtue and social epistemology connect knowing with competence and responsibility, while natural science evaluates claims through publicly corrigible methods rather than the moral attainment of a claimant.

The four approaches diagnose different primary errors. Madhyasth Darshan identifies incomplete or misdirected activity of *jeevan* and contradiction between realization and conduct. Advaita identifies superimposition of body-mind and Self, removed by Upanishadic knowledge. Analytic epistemology distinguishes falsehood, luck, unreliable formation, and social distortion; science institutionalizes controls against measurement error, confounding, bias, and failed prediction. A comparative test must ask whether each method can detect the errors to which its own practitioners are vulnerable.

5.2 Sat-Chit-Ananda versus distributed coexistence

Advaita's Sat-Chit-Ananda and Madhyasth Darshan's coexistence can sound alike — both speak of being, consciousness, and fulfilment. The contrast is over what those words name and whether the world survives them (The Ontology of Coexistence §5.6).

Concept	Advaita Vedanta (unified non-dualism)	Madhyasth Darshan (distributed coexistence)
Sat (Being)	Brahman is independent reality; names and forms have dependent empirical reality.	Beingness (*astitva*) is coexistence of formless Omnipresence and countless real units.
Chit (Consciousness)	Self-revealing consciousness identical with Self and Brahman; empirical mind and objects are not independently conscious.	Omnipresence is pervasive knowledge or condition of intelligibility (§1.1), while active sentience (*chaitanya*) belongs to each *jeevan*. The concurrence of *atma* with Omnipresence in ultimate bliss (§1.2) relates a unit to the ground; it does not dissolve the unit.
Ananda (Fullness or bliss)	Limitless fullness of Brahman, not a passing mental pleasure.	Harmony realized within awakened *jeevan* and expressed as humane conduct.

Modern philosophy has no parallel formula: it may treat experience as physical, fundamental, or illusory, but it does not name existence as Sat-Chit-Ananda or as coexistence.

5.3 Partially incommensurable epistemic criteria

The four approaches do not merely give different answers; they use different criteria for what counts as knowing:

Tradition	Method	Adequate for
Madhyasth Darshan	Study, realization, behaviour, experiment	Coexistence as lived evidence; conduct as proof of understanding
Advaita	Upanishadic testimony, reasoning, and contemplative discrimination (§§2.1–2.7)	Valid empirical cognition and removal of ignorance of Self–Brahman identity
Modern Western philosophy	Argument, experience, justification, reliability, virtue, and social practice (§3)	Conceptual warrant and accounts of first- and third-person knowing
Natural sciences	Observation, modelling, replication, peer review (§4)	Mechanism, prediction, and public correction

They are partially incommensurable because each includes standards the others do not fully recognise. Comparison can nevertheless test internal consistency, fidelity to experience, fit with public knowledge, explanatory reach, and whether a claimed method controls its own characteristic errors. The remaining disputes are collected in §7.

6. Critical Review

No view escapes serious objections. Here is where each is strong and where each is vulnerable.

6.1 Madhyasth Darshan — integrated inside, unproven outside

Strengths.

- It integrates ontology, active selfhood, knowledge, action, value, and social evidence rather than treating epistemology as belief assessment alone.
- KD's linked triads connect perspective, realization, action, result, and evaluation; conduct therefore has genuine epistemic weight.
- Its distinction between cognisance and sensitivity explains why bodily propensities, sensory contact, and social motives require knowledgeable regulation without being rejected.

- The knowledge–wisdom–science differentiation connects truth, human purpose, and practical direction, while SB extends that direction to productive and ecological complementarity.
- Its realism preserves the final significance of nature, individual sentient units, and human relationships.

Weaknesses.

- The claims that Omnipresence is Knowledge and that a constitutionally complete atom is the knower are not independently established by physical measurement.
- The relation between *jeevan* and measured brain activity remains underspecified (§7.3).
- Conduct-evidence does not yet discriminate Madhyasth Darshan's ontology from rival paths that also produce resolution or humane action.
- The asserted passage from resolved knowledge and just relationship to mutual satisfaction and the four *jeevan* values needs operational descriptions that can distinguish durable harmony from conformity, self-report, or temporary affect.
- The method needs safeguards against circularity when awakening validates the teaching and the teaching identifies awakening, as well as a clearer boundary between structural certitude and corrigible empirical knowledge (§§7.1 and 7.5).

Madhyasth Darshan is best read as an internally integrated epistemology whose decisive tests remain conduct-based and publicly contestable, not as a demonstrated ontology.

6.2 Advaita Vedanta — disciplined self-inquiry, disputed non-duality

Strengths.

- Advaita distinguishes ordinary cognition from the consciousness in whose presence cognition is manifest, preventing a simple identification of the knower with any passing mental state.
- Its analysis of superimposition explains how bodily, affective, and cognitive predicates become fused with the sense of self.
- Its account of empirical *pramanas*, qualified instruction, reasoning, and contemplation is more epistemically articulated than a generic appeal to mystical experience.
- Ethical discipline and *loka-sangraha* answer the claim that non-duality simply licenses withdrawal from empirical responsibility.

Weaknesses.

- Its move from the non-objectifiability of witnessing consciousness to identity with Brahman requires Upanishadic testimony and interpretive argument; introspection alone does not establish cosmic non-duality.
- The relation of beginningless ignorance to non-dual Brahman remains contested. Calling *avidya* dependent and neither absolutely real nor sheer non-being protects non-

duality, but critics can still ask whether this explains the appearance of plurality or restates its anomalous status.

- The empirical validity of suffering, duty, and relationship supports serious ethics, yet their final sublation gives them a different ontological standing from the perpetual relations asserted by Madhyasth Darshan.
- Later Advaita models of *jiva*, reflection, Maya, and levels of reality are not uniform; comparison must not treat one scholastic formulation as the uncontested view of the entire tradition.

Advaita offers a rigorous account of liberating Self-knowledge when its empirical and absolute levels are kept distinct. Its central comparative vulnerability is not ethical incapacity but the additional argument needed to move from witness analysis to non-dual metaphysics, together with the final dependence it assigns to the plural world.

6.3 Modern Western philosophy — plural resources, no settled knower

Strengths.

- Analytic epistemology supplies precise tools for justification, reliability, testimony, intellectual competence, epistemic luck, and social error.
- Phenomenology and embodied approaches describe lived and bodily access to the world without reducing experience to an afterthought.
- Social epistemology explains why testimony, institutions, trust, and power partly constitute the conditions under which individuals know.

Weaknesses.

- The plurality of approaches can fragment the relation among warranted belief, consciousness, understanding, value, and conduct.
- A theory may explain when a proposition counts as known without explaining the nature of the subject who knows it.
- Physicalist, phenomenological, enactive, idealist, and social accounts can share vocabulary while disagreeing about what the knower and known ultimately are.

Modern Western philosophy makes the conceptual alternatives explicit but does not deliver a single replacement for the integrated Madhyasth Darshan triad.

6.4 Natural sciences — powerful correction, bounded scope

Strengths.

- Measurement, intervention, prediction, replication, and adversarial testing provide powerful controls against individual conviction being mistaken for public knowledge.

- Neuroscience establishes detailed dependencies among brain, body, behaviour, report, and cognitive capacity without requiring premature agreement on a final metaphysics of consciousness.
- Public methods enable correction across observers, instruments, cultures, and generations.

Weaknesses.

- **The hard problem.** Neural dependence and correlation do not yet explain why physical processing has a first-person aspect (§§3.4 and 4.3).
- **First-person calibration.** Reports and experiential descriptions can enter science, but their public calibration may omit aspects of experience that are difficult to operationalize; no agreed method fully coordinates phenomenological structure with neural explanation (§§3.4 and 4.1).
- **Normative limitation.** Descriptive success does not by itself establish justice, humane purpose, or the values by which knowledge should be used (§4.5).
- **Theory competition.** Consciousness science has several live but competing programmes and no settled account of the knower (§4.3).

The natural sciences offer the strongest method for public correction, but the claim that their current ontology is the complete account of knowledge and the knower remains philosophical rather than an experimental result.

7. Open problems for Madhyasth Darshan epistemology

7.1 Holistic knowability versus fallibilism

Madhyasth Darshan holds that the structure of coexistence, *jeevan*, and humane conduct can be understood without ontological mystery (§1.5). It does not follow that an awakened person knows every contingent fact. The system needs a clearer account of which claims are held with final certitude, which remain open to empirical correction, and how mistaken certainty would be diagnosed from within the method.

7.2 Conduct-evidence and public testability

Realisation, authenticity, behaviour, experiment, and transmission form Madhyasth Darshan 's evidence regime (§1.5). Science requires operational and reproducible discrimination among competing explanations. Public evaluation of *jeevan* would require at minimum:

1. **Operational criteria** for constitutional completeness independent of the philosophy.
2. **Reproducible markers** distinguishing *jeevan*-mediated from brain-only activity.
3. **Independent evidence** for post-death continuity of a sentient unit.

Until then, immortal *jeevan* remains a metaphysical commitment not validated by current science. Realisation as *pramana* is an epistemic criterion, not itself a metaphysical entity; the open question is whether its conduct and transmission tests can distinguish Madhyasth Darshan's ontology from rival paths that also produce resolution or ethical conduct. The explanatory gap in consciousness is not by itself evidence for *jeevan*.

7.3 *Jeevan*–body interaction and physical causation

If *jeevan* coordinates the body through the joint form (§1.3), either it makes a measurable difference to neural activity or "driving" names a non-mechanical relation that still requires specification. The texts' signal language is more precise than a crude Cartesian push, but it does not yet answer the closure-based objection or show what observations would differ if *jeevan* were absent.

7.4 Post-death continuity as inference, not measurement

Post-death survival of *jeevan* is inferred from constitutional completeness and conservation (§1.1), not established by third-person observation. Quantity conservation alone does not guarantee entity identity. Madhyasth Darshan's account of liberation from molecular- and weight-bondage must therefore carry the argument and remains an open point of contact with physics and mereology (The Ontology of Coexistence §6.2.3).

7.5 Teacher, tradition, and circular validation

Madhyasth Darshan requires guidance from a realised human and treats successful conveyance as evidence (§1.5). This creates a productive second-person discipline but also a circularity risk: the teacher may be recognised as realised through the doctrine, while the doctrine is trusted through the teacher. The tradition needs explicit safeguards for disagreement, failed transmission, authority error, and correction of a respected teacher.

7.6 Non-substitutable evidence across domains

The darshan expects coherence across realisation, thought, relationship, work, result, and social participation. It does not yet state a public rule for cases in which the domains diverge: sound conduct with disputed metaphysics, contemplative certitude with failed prediction, or successful production with unjust relationships. CFP's recovery audit suggests the right discipline — success in one domain must not silently substitute for failure in another — but the criteria for adjudicating such mixed cases remain to be developed in ordinary prose and practice.

7.7 From regulation to *jeevan* values

The primary texts give a strong conceptual bridge from knowledge through regulation and just relationship to happiness, peace, contentment, and bliss (§§1.2 and 1.4). They give less detail about how an observer or community should assess that bridge in difficult cases. A practical epistemology still needs criteria for distinguishing restraint from repression, prosperity from accumulation, public participation from reputation-seeking, beneficence from dependency-making, mutual satisfaction from mere agreement, and stable faculty-harmony from temporary positive affect. It also needs an account of cases in which correct intention and competent effort meet refusal, material scarcity, illness, or conflict beyond one person's control. These questions do not negate the value structure; they identify the next work required to make its claimed evidence intersubjectively discriminating.

8. Conclusion

Madhyasth Darshan's distinctive contribution to comparative epistemology is not merely an additional definition of knowledge. It joins the intelligibility of coexistence, *jeevan* as the active knower, humane conduct as part of what must be known, and the consequences of action as evidence that returns to the knower. Because the human being is a unit of the knowledge order whose *dharma* is happiness, this understanding must govern bodily propensities, sensory engagement, social motives, relationship, production, and participation in nature. Knowledge, knower, and known become complete together when knowledge, wisdom, and science are stable across realisation, thought, relationship, work, evaluation, and transmission. This gives epistemology an ethical, ecological, and civilisational reach that neither belief-centred analysis nor mechanism-centred science ordinarily claims.

The comparison also fixes the limits of that contribution. Advaita offers a more radical account of the witness by dissolving the triad at the highest level; Madhyasth Darshan preserves the distinction and participation of real units within coexistence. Modern Western philosophy provides plural accounts of warrant, embodiment, first-person experience, and social knowledge. Natural science supplies the strongest available procedures for public correction and causal explanation. Madhyasth Darshan must therefore show how realisation and conduct-evidence control error without circularity, and how claims about *jeevan* differ observationally from biological accounts.

The primary texts thus support a layered epistemic structure. Knowledge has coexistence, *jeevan*, and humane conduct as its canonical contents; it governs bodily propensities through sensory engagement, resolution and the three *eshanas* in social life, and *upakar* as higher-human participation. Deliberation considers pleasantness, bodily well-being, and material gain under the governing perspectives of justice, *dharma*, and truth, while law, regulation, and balance connect understanding to orderly activity. Knowing and accepting continue through recognition, fulfilment, result, evaluation, correction, and transmission. This structure explains the framework's coherence without removing its open problems: its claims still require clearer public tests, intersubjective safeguards, and dialogue with the sciences.

Appendix: Quick Glossary

Key terms from §§1–4 are collected here for quick reference. Most are defined where they first appear; the glossary also preserves compact technical structures that the exposition does not develop at length.

Terms in §1

Term	Plain meaning
Coexistence (*saha-astitva*)	Reality as the pervasive ground (*satta*) and all units (*ikai*) inseparably present together.
***Anubhav jnan* (Realisation Knowledge)**	Saturated insentient and sentient nature, whose units have form, properties, essential nature, *dharma*, and orderliness (MVD, p. 11; §1.1).
Gyan udghatan	The unfolding of knowledge through awakened humans or the sentient aspect, not cognition performed by Omnipresence (§1.1).
***Samadhan* (Resolution)**	Realised knowledge established as freedom from contradiction, with correct answers to why and how for activity; also grouped with the three *eshanas* in intellectual satisfaction (§§1.2 and 1.4).
Gyan–vivek–vigyan	Knowledge of coexistence, *jeevan*, and humane conduct; wisdom that recognises the human goal; and science that determines direction for material prosperity and the human and *jeevan* goals (§1.2).
Knowledge–knower–known	Knowledge of coexistence, *jeevan*, and humane conduct; *jeevan* as bearer of knowing; coexistence as object made meaningful in awakened living (§1.1).
Darshan–drish–drishya / drishti	KD's compact trio assigns *darshan* to justice, *dharma*, and truth, *drish* to human *jeevan*, and *drishya* to coexistence; its exposition establishes awakened *jeevan* as seer and *darshan* as meaningful exposition. MVD uses *drishti* for perspective (KD §3.17, pp. 145–150; MVD, p. 84).
Dhyan–dhyata–dhyeya	KD's attention structure: awakening, the human attender, and freedom from delusion together with the *jeevan* values and evidence of the human goal; the explanatory prose treats awakening as the object of understood attention (KD §3.17, pp. 145–150).
Karan–karta–karya	Cause–doer–effect at two levels: knowledge-state–human–universal participation, and coexistence–*jeevan*–awakened human status (KD §3.17, pp. 145–150).

Term	Plain meaning
Sadhya–sadhak–sadhan	Awakening or seer-status as aim, the human being as seeker, and body together with *jeevan* as means; tradition, imagination, and freedom of action support those means (KD §3.17, pp. 145–150).
***Sapekshata* (Relativity)**	Differentiation among perspective, observed scene, and worldview; in this context, the changing relativity of sensory, bodily, and material criteria rather than unreality of coexistence (§1.4).
Six evaluative perspectives	*Priya–apriya* concerns sensory pleasantness, *hita–ahita* bodily well-being, *labha–alabha* material gain, *nyaya–anyaya* relationship and behaviour, *dharma–adharma* resolution and orderly participation, and *satya–asatya* realisation in existence (§1.4).
Five forces / five powers	KD's second description of the ten activities: five activities of state expressed as force and five of motion expressed as power, the projected five appearing as hope, thought, desire, resoluteness, and authenticity (KD §3.6, pp. 70–71; KD §3.16, p. 145).
***Madhyasthata* (Mediativeness)**	The central, non-partisan situation of *atma* by which the mediative activity attains the touch of knowledge in every dimension, evidenced only through integrality of behaviour and thought (MVD, p. 211).
Higher- / lower-conformance	Governance of *mun* by inspiration from *vritti*, *chitta*, *buddhi*, and *atma*, against governance by pressure from *prana*, senses, body, and behaviour (MVD, p. 208; §1.3).
***Manah-swasthata* (Mental well-being)**	The realisation of happiness, peace, contentment, and bliss in the state of higher-conformance (MVD, p. 208; §1.2).
Sanvedansheelta* / *sangyansheelta	Sensitivity through the body and senses, and cognisance through *jeevan*'s knowing and accepting. Cognisance regulates sensitivity (§1.3).
Four *vishayas*	Eating, sleeping, defending, and mating: bodily propensities retained in the human joint form and regulated rather than treated as the source of *jeevan*'s happiness (§1.4).
Five sensory modalities	Sound, touch, visible form, taste, and smell: bodily interfaces through which the four *vishayas* are engaged, not five further propensities or a stable category of "five *samvedanas*" (§1.4).
Three *eshanas*	Progeny, wealth, and public-recognition motives, defined through family and society, prosperity and right use, and undivided society or universal orderliness (§1.4).

Term	Plain meaning
Niyam–niyantran–santulan	Law protecting and disciplining activity, regulation according to law, and the balance it sustains; connected sequentially to justice, *dharma*, and truth rather than paired with them one-to-one (§1.4).
Nyaya / ***ubhay-trupti***	Justice as relationship-recognition, value-fulfilment, evaluation, and mutual satisfaction. Mutual satisfaction is a relational outcome, not a fifth *jeevan* value (§§1.4–1.5).
Humane conduct (value, character, ethics)	KD's third content of knowledge: relationship value with evaluation and mutual satisfaction; character as fidelity and compassionate conduct; ethics as protection and right use of body, mind, and wealth (KD §3.4, p. 67; MVD, p. 35; §§1.1 and 1.4).
Ati-, av-, mithya-mulyankan	Over-evaluation, under-evaluation, and mis-evaluation of objects, relationships, fulfilment, or results (§1.5).
***Upakar* (Beneficence)**	Help and inspiration for prosperity and awakening; higher-human application and evidence, not a fourth *eshana* or the sole proof of knowledge (§1.4).
Pramana	Means or proof of valid knowledge; in Madhyasth Darshan, realization (*anubhav*) evidenced in conduct is the ultimate proof.
***Pramanikta* (Authenticity)**	The realisation-bearing activity of *atma* that becomes publicly evident through conduct, teaching, and humane tradition (§1.5).
Pratyaksha–sakshatkar–bodh–anubhav	Direct accessibility; meaning-acceptance in *chitta*; enlightenment in *buddhi*; and realisation in *atma*. These are related but non-interchangeable (§1.5).
Projection / reflection	The evidencing and knowing directions of *jeevan*'s ten coordinated activities (§1.3).
Seer–doer–enjoyer	Understanding, action, and fruition unified in the awakened human joint form (KD §3.18, pp. 151–152).
Bhram	Delusion — living by inherited belief rather than understanding, rooted in identifying *jeevan* with the body.
***Rahasyata* (Mysteriousness)**	Incapacity to attain, evidence, or impart complete understanding (§1.5).
***Bauddhik rahasya* (Intellectual mystery)**	Failure of reflection and alignment among the faculties of *jeevan* (§1.5).
***Anushandhan* (Exploration)**	Inventive comprehensive study from decline through development and awakening to Omnipresence (MVD, Ch. 17; §1.5).

Term	Plain meaning
Jeevan	The sentient self — in Shri Nagraj's view a real, eternal, atom-scale entity that works *through* the body. Ontology: The Ontology of Coexistence.
***Drishta-pad* (Seer status)**	The unique capacity of the human being in existence to observe, understand, and evaluate all orders of nature.
Human *dharma*	Happiness as the inseparable human aspiration; knowledge is required to understand and live the law by which happiness is realised (§1.2).
Human aspiration	Resolution, prosperity, fearlessness, and coexistence at person, family, society, and universal-order scales (§1.2).
***Jeevan* aspiration**	Happiness, peace, contentment, and bliss as harmonies of *jeevan* (§1.2).

Terms in §2

Term	Plain meaning
Atman* / *Brahman	In Advaita Vedanta: the innermost Self / the one ultimate, non-dual reality.
Pramatr–pramana–prameya–prama	Empirical knower, means of valid cognition, known object, and resulting valid cognition; this structure operates at *vyavahara* (§§2.1 and 2.6).
Jiva	The embodied empirical knower and agent under ignorance; its apparent separateness is sublated in liberating knowledge.
Sakshin	The actionless witnessing consciousness that illumines changing cognitions without becoming another empirical cognitive instrument.
Sat-Chit-Ananda	A later compact Advaita expression for Brahman as existence, consciousness, and limitless fullness; related to but not identical with TU 2.1.1's wording.
Chit	Advaita: consciousness as the very nature of Brahman and the inner Self.
Svaprakasha	Advaita: consciousness self-luminous — reveals itself without another knower (§2.2).

Term	Plain meaning
***Badha* (Sublation)**	Cancellation of a cognition or claim to independent reality by a cognition with greater authority (§2.3).
Mithya	Dependent empirical reality: neither independently absolute nor sheer non-being.
Moksha	Advaita: liberation as recognition of pre-existing identity with Brahman (§2.7).

Terms in §3

Term	Plain meaning
Scientific realism	The view that successful scientific theories aim to describe a mind-independent world, including well-supported unobservable entities (§3.3).
Hard Problem	Why physical brain processes are accompanied by subjective experience — a modern open question, not the same as Madhyasth Darshan's *rahasyata* (§1.5; §3.4).

Terms in §4

Term	Plain meaning
Methodological naturalism	The scientific policy of seeking publicly testable natural explanations without assuming that current physicalism is complete.
Replication	Independent repetition of a method or test as a control on error and investigator-specific conviction (§4.4).
Neural correlate	A brain state or process systematically associated with a conscious capacity or report; correlation alone does not decide metaphysical identity (§4.2).

References

Madhyasth Darshan (primary sources)

- **MVD** — Nagraj, A. *Madhyasth Darshan – Co-existentialism, Part 1: Holistic View of Human Behaviour*. English translation by Rakesh Gupta. Cited: all units in Omnipresence (p. 11); evidence chain and "Believe what is known" (p. 12); the four registers of the omnipresent ground (p. 33); Space as knowledge, knowledge as neither activity nor performing activity, and humane behaviour as essential nature, perspective,

and motives (p. 35); four bodily propensities (p. 58); sensory and intellectual satisfaction and the three *eshanas* (pp. 64–65); six evaluative perspectives (pp. 66–67); law and the activities of thought (pp. 70–71); *upakar* as help and inspiration for prosperity and awakening (p. 73); *medhas*, the *jeevan* activities, and *darshan-drishya-drishti* (pp. 83–84); *sanskar* definition (p. 90); the universality argument for knowledge and "Realisation in coexistence" (pp. 115–116); balanced and unbalanced deliberation (pp. 126–127); regulation through justice, *dharma*, truth, and law (p. 137); *vivek* and *vigyan* definitions (p. 170); the sequence from knowledge through law, regulation, balance, justice, *dharma*, and truth (p. 174); false learning (p. 184); the brain and cognitive-organ signal pathway (p. 200); higher- and lower-conformance, the four *jeevan* values, and mental well-being (pp. 207–208); mediativeness of *atma* (p. 211); doubt and distorted evaluation (pp. 263–264); Ch. 17 *Rahasy-mukti* — mystery, exploration, study, and an awakened tradition (pp. 273–301); knowledge unfolding through *jeevan*/thought (p. 289); the awakening–*sanskar* cycle (p. 290); justice, mutual satisfaction, and resolution (pp. 310–311); *samvedana* usages (p. 313); delusion-less knowledge (p. 317); and *atma*–Omnipresence concurrence and ultimate bliss (p. 327).

- **KD** — Nagraj, A. *Manav Karm Darshan* (Madhyasth Darshan, Part 2). Working English translation; Hindi–English review edition. Cited by paraphrase: autobiographical *Alternative* (points 1, 5, 10, and 11), including the founding questions on Brahma and the world and on what counts as evidence; action, desire, result, and the reinterpreted human ends (Ch. 1, pp. 2–4); direct perception, inference, and testimony-activity (pp. 20–21); humane conduct as value, character, and ethics (§3.4, p. 67); four contents of complete knowledge (§3.5, p. 69); five activities of state and five of motion as force and power (§3.6, pp. 70–71); *jeevan* expressing hope, thought, desire, resoluteness, and evidence (p. 65); the relation between the human goal and the *jeevan* values (p. 112); projection–reflection (§§3.12, 3.16–3.17); body–*jeevan* dependence and the projected activities in the *medhas* setting (§3.16, pp. 141, 143, 145); the knowledge–knower–known argument, ten activities, and the knowledge, attention, cause, and aim triads (§3.17, pp. 145–150); and seer–doer–enjoyer (§3.18, pp. 151–152). The English text is a working translation; quoted formulations should be checked against the Hindi.
- **SB** — Nagraj, A. *Samadhanatmak Bhautikvad (Resolution Centred Materialism)*. English translation by Rakesh Gupta. Cited: evidence through experimentation, behaviour, and experience (p. 44); balance of cognisance and sensitivity (p. 64); material and ecological complementarity and cyclic economic participation (pp. 111, 121, 149); and threefold knowledge (p. 116).
- **JV** — Nagraj, A. *Jeevan Vidya: An Introduction*. English translation by Rakesh Gupta. Cited: birth, death, and *jeevan* continuity (p. 20); proof by conveying understanding (p. 26); recognition, fulfilment, evaluation, and mutual satisfaction in justice (p. 55); the human goal (pp. 61, 165); ten activities and the four-and-a-half activities effective in delusion (pp. 72–74, 92–93); the root of delusion and the governance of pleasure,

health, and profit by justice, *dharma*, and truth (pp. 93–98, 139); the four *jeevan* values (p. 138); and the definition of knowledge (p. 165).

Advaita Vedanta (primary texts)

- **BG** — *Bhagavad Gita*. Cited: field and knower of the field (13.1–13.3); prescribed action (3.8); *loka-sangraha* and action by the enlightened (3.20, 3.25–26).
- **BU** — *Brihadaranyaka Upanishad*. Cited: *neti neti* (2.3.6); *shravana–manana–nididhyasana* (2.4.5).
- **DDV** — *Drig-Drishya-Viveka* (traditionally attributed to Shankara or Bharati Tirtha; authorship disputed). Cited: seer and seen discrimination (p. 15).
- **BSB** — Shankara, Adi. *Brahma Sutra Bhashya*. Cited: the *Adhyasa Bhashya* (preamble) on superimposition of self and not-self; Brahman as source of the universe (1.1.2); Upanishadic knowledge and removal of ignorance.
- **CU** — *Chandogya Upanishad*. Cited: clay analogy (6.1.4); "one only, without a second" (6.2.1); *tat tvam asi* (6.8.7).
- **MU** — *Mandukya Upanishad*. Cited: three states and *turiya* (vv. 3–7).
- **TU** — *Taittiriya Upanishad*. Cited: Brahman as Truth, Knowledge, and Infinity (2.1.1); five sheaths (2.1–2.5).
- **VC** — *Vivekachudamani* (traditionally attributed to Shankara; authorship disputed). Cited as a later pedagogical witness: qualification (vv. 17–20); five sheaths (vv. 154–212); Existence-Knowledge-Bliss (v. 152); Maya, Ishvara, and *jiva* (vv. 243–244); *jiva* as Brahman (v. 216); Brahman as one's own Self (v. 393); liberation without seeker or bound soul (v. 574).
- **VP** — Dharmaraja Adhvarindra. *Vedanta Paribhasa*. Later systematic manual cited for the sixfold *pramana* account and empirical cognition (§2.6).

Related studies in this collection

- The Ontology of Coexistence — Omnipresence and saturation (§§1.1–1.2), *jeevan* faculties and projection–reflection (§1.7), realisation and the knowledge–knower–known relation (§1.13), Sat-Chit-Ananda contrast (§5.6), and open evidence problems (§6.2).
- Coexistence From First Principles — interpretive reconstruction of the knowledge-order cycle, karma and conduct-evidence, and non-substitutable human goals (§§4.13–4.15); used conceptually here without its notation.
- Human Behavior and Society — manifest, effable knowledge versus mystery-based ineffability (§3).
- *Spiritual-Practice-And-Realization* (Ongoing) — *dhyan*, yoga, six flaws, and the detailed practice path related to §1.5.

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- **Churchland 1986** — Churchland, P. S. *Neurophilosophy: Toward a Unified Science of the Mind-Brain*. MIT Press.
- **Dennett 1991** — Dennett, D. *Consciousness Explained*. Little, Brown.
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- **Jarczewski and Riggs 2025** — Jarczewski, D., and Riggs, W. D. "Socializing Virtue Epistemology." *Episteme*, First View, 1–19.
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